

Bustards

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Otidiformes
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	26

Most species of bustard are threatened; dependence on extensive, undisturbed habitats makes them increasingly vulnerable. They are large to very large, including some of the world's heaviest flying birds. Long, strong legs and stout toes hint at their terrestrial lifestyle, but long, broad wings make them powerful fliers when necessary.

Males have dramatic displays early in the breeding season.

HOUBARA BUSTARD
Long white plumes provide an impressive display for the houbara.



Chlamydotis undulata

Houbara bustard



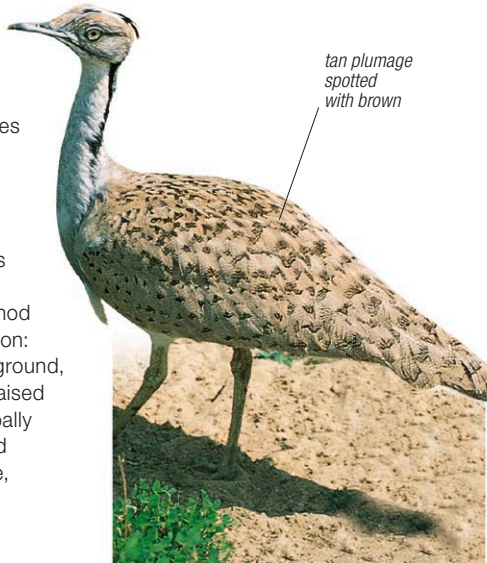
Length 26–30 in (65–75 cm)
Weight 3¼–6½ lb (1.5–3 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Vulnerable

Location Canary Islands, N. Africa, W., C., and E. Asia



This stout, long-legged bird is a typical member of the bustard family—a group of about 26 species that are found only in the Eastern Hemisphere. Like other bustards, it has cryptically colored plumage, and although it can fly well, it spends most of its time on

the ground. The houbara bustard searches for food as it walks through its desert homeland, eating seeds and shoots, insects, and small reptiles such as lizards. Of all bustards, it is the one best adapted to the desert, and seldom drinks, obtaining most of the water it needs from food. The male uses a traditional courtship arena for mating, adopting a curious method of attracting the females' attention: it trots blindly about its display ground, with its ruff and crest feathers raised over its head. Although not globally threatened, the houbara bustard is declining fast across its range, and in many parts of West Asia, it is the focus of intensive conservation measures.



Kori bustard

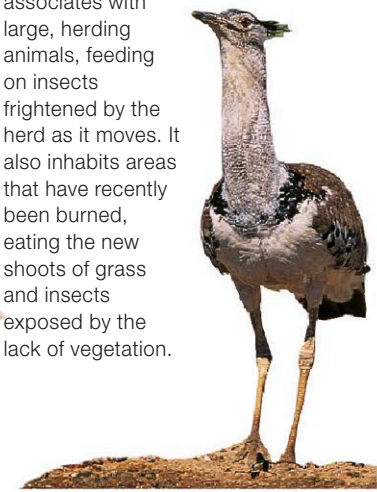


Length 4 ft (1.2 m)
Weight 24–42 lb (11–19 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened

Location E. and southern Africa



Weighing up to 42 lb (19 kg), the kori bustard is one of the world's heaviest flying birds. Like its relatives, however, it lives on the ground and is reluctant to fly unless in serious danger. It often associates with large, herding animals, feeding on insects frightened by the herd as it moves. It also inhabits areas that have recently been burned, eating the new shoots of grass and insects exposed by the lack of vegetation.



Mesites

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Mesitornithiformes
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	3

Mesites are relatively little known—even their relationship with other bird families is obscure. Although possibly related to pigeons, their appearance and behavior suggests no close relationship with other groups.

SUB-DESERT MESITE
A downcurved bill used for digging insects from the soil distinguishes this species. It lives in low-level thorny thickets.



Mesitornis variegata

White-breasted mesite



Length 12 in (31 cm)
Weight 3½ oz (100 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Vulnerable

Location Madagascar



This small forest bird is one of 3 species in the mesite family, all unique to Madagascar, and threatened by the destruction of their natural habitat. Its

short, rounded wings and stout legs are typical of a ground-living bird. It feeds mainly on insects and spiders, flicking through fallen leaves or lifting up larger ones in order to find prey. A tangled mass of vegetation piled into a tree or bush, ¾–9¼ ft (1–3 m) above the ground, serves as a nest.



Seriemas

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Cariamiformes
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	2

The strikingly upright stance of the seriemas resembles the larger, flightless rheas. Usually striding around in pairs, they can fly but rarely do so, nesting and roosting in the safety of treetops.

RED-LEGGED SERIEMA
This long-legged bird associates with domestic livestock, catching insects and reptiles disturbed by the animals.



Cariama cristata

Red-legged seriema



Length 30–35 in (75–90 cm)
Weight 3¼ lb (1.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Location E. South America



In both shape and behavior, this species resembles the secretary bird (see p.296): both have long legs and crests, and both hunt by striding across the ground. The

red-legged seriema often captures large prey in its bill, beating it on the ground to break it into pieces. It usually runs from predators, but may lie down and rely on its cryptic coloring to escape detection. Out of the breeding season it is highly vocal, and its call is one of the most characteristic sounds of South American grasslands. Although generally solitary, this species may also be found in groups at times.

